

In Chapter 1 of "Goodbye, Daddy,"

the protagonist, Bennie Carson, narrates the heart-wrenching experience of his father leaving their family when he was just eight years old. His mother breaks the news to him and his brother, Curtis, explaining that their father has done "bad things" and has to leave for good. Bennie struggles to accept this reality, clinging to the hope of his parents reconciling and their family staying together.

Bennie recalls fond memories of his father, depicting him as affectionate and patient. He remembers their Sunday drives and his father's playful interactions, which contrast with the harsh truth of his departure. Despite his mother's reassurances of his father's love, Bennie cannot comprehend why his father is leaving and desperately pleads for him to return.

As time passes, Bennie grapples with the absence of his father, praying for their reunion and struggling to understand the reasons behind his departure. Despite his initial belief that his parents should stay together, Bennie gradually comes to accept their separation as he witnesses the peace and stability in their household without his father's presence.

Bennie reflects on his mother's resilience and sacrifices, acknowledging her as the pillar of their family. Despite the financial struggles caused by his father's absence, Bennie admires his mother's unwavering dedication and faith in providing for them. He credits her strength and guidance as instrumental in shaping his own character and achievements.

The excerpt details the profound influence of Sonya Carson, Ben Carson's mother, on his life, particularly during challenging times following his father's departure from their home. At the tender age of 8, Ben was devastated when his mother broke the news that his father would not be returning home. Despite his tears and pleas, Ben's father never came back, leaving a void in his young heart.

Sonya Carson, however, remained a pillar of strength for Ben and his brother Curtis. Despite the financial strain caused by their father's absence, Sonya worked tirelessly to provide for her sons, instilling in them a sense of security and confidence. Despite the hardships they faced, Sonya maintained an unwavering belief that they would be fine, fostering a sense of contentment and assurance in her children.

Sonya's resilience and dedication left a lasting impression on Ben. Her deep faith in God and her innate ability to inspire her sons instilled in Ben a sense of hope and determination. Despite the challenges they faced, Ben never doubted his mother's love and commitment to their well-being.

Sonya's influence extended beyond providing for her sons' physical needs. She also imparted invaluable life lessons, teaching them the importance of perseverance, sacrifice, and faith. Her strength and unwavering support laid the foundation for Ben's future successes, shaping him into the accomplished individual he would become.

In conclusion, Sonya Carson's influence on Ben Carson's life was profound and far-reaching. Her unwavering love, resilience, and dedication served as guiding lights during challenging times, instilling in Ben the values and principles that would shape his future achievements.

Chapter 2

The excerpt further explores the significant influence of Sonya Carson on Ben Carson's life, highlighting her determination, resilience, and sacrifice in shaping her sons' futures. Despite facing adversity, Sonya remained steadfast in her commitment to providing for her children and instilling in them a sense of confidence and ambition.

Sonya's character is described as that of a classic Type A personality—hardworking, goal-oriented, and driven to demand the best from herself and her children. Despite her limited education, Sonya possessed a keen intuition and a clear understanding of how to navigate life's challenges. She refused to allow the system to dictate her family's fate and instead took control of their future.

Ben reflects on his mother's unwavering support and encouragement, even when he and his brother resisted her guidance. Sonya's constant reminders that they were capable of achieving greatness became ingrained in Ben's psyche, shaping his self-belief and determination to succeed.

Despite their father's absence, Sonya ensured that her sons received the care and attention they needed, arranging for them to stay with neighbours when she had to be away. Later, Ben learned that these absences were due to his mother seeking treatment for mental health issues resulting from the strain of divorce and financial struggles. Despite facing judgement and gossip from their community, Sonya remained resilient and focused on providing for her sons.

Eventually, Sonya made the difficult decision to move her family to Boston, where they were taken in by her sister and brother-in-law. Despite her own challenges, Sonya ensured that her sons were cared for and loved, shielding them from the full extent of her struggles.

In conclusion, Sonya Carson's unwavering love, determination, and resilience had a profound impact on Ben Carson's life. Her ability to overcome adversity and provide for her children despite facing personal challenges served as a guiding light for Ben and his brother Curtis, instilling in them the belief that they could overcome any obstacle and achieve their dreams.

Chapter 3

Summary:

In this section of Ben Carson's memoir, several key events shape his early childhood and academic struggles, as well as his aspirations for the future.

1. **Early Religious Influence and Decision to Follow Christ:**

- Ben recalls a sermon where the pastor tells a story about a couple seeking refuge in the cleft of a rock, illustrating God's protection. This sermon deeply affects Ben, leading him to make an emotional decision to accept Jesus Christ into his life at the age of eight. He and his brother Curtis both join the church and are baptized.

2. **Aspiration to Become a Doctor:**

- Ben's exposure to stories of missionary doctors during church services ignites a passion within him to become a doctor himself. Despite his young age, Ben decides that he wants to pursue a career in medicine, specifically as a missionary doctor.
3. **Challenges in School and Perseverance:**
 - Ben's academic journey is marked by significant challenges, particularly when his family moves back to Detroit from Boston. He struggles academically, feeling overwhelmed by the rigorous curriculum and the competitiveness of his classmates. Despite being teased and taunted for his poor grades, Ben maintains a determined attitude and refuses to give up.
 4. **Family's Financial Struggles and Mother's Determination:**
 - Ben's family faces financial difficulties, prompting them to move to a lower-income neighborhood in Detroit. His mother, Sonya Carson, works multiple jobs to make ends meet, demonstrating resilience and resourcefulness. Despite the hardships, Sonya remains determined to reclaim their former home and instills in her sons the belief that they can achieve success.
 5. **Impact of Racial Stereotypes:**
 - Ben's struggles in school are compounded by racial stereotypes, as he begins to internalize the belief that Black children are not as smart as White ones. He experiences a particularly humiliating moment when his low test score is publicly mocked by his classmates, reinforcing his feelings of inadequacy.
 6. **Turning Point and Resilience:**
 - Despite the challenges and moments of despair, Ben's determination remains unwavering. He refuses to succumb to self-doubt and begins to challenge the negative perceptions of his abilities. This section ends with Ben's resilience in the face of adversity, setting the stage for his future journey towards academic and professional success.

Initially, Ben describes his struggles academically upon returning to the Detroit public school system from a private church school in Boston. Placed in a predominantly White school, Ben finds himself at the bottom of his class, unable to keep up with his peers academically. Despite his efforts, he becomes the target of teasing and taunting from his classmates, which further exacerbates his feelings of inadequacy and isolation. Ben's low self-esteem is reinforced by his belief that Black children are not as smart as White ones, perpetuating a harmful stereotype.

The turning point in Ben's perception comes during a maths quiz, where he scores only nine out of 30 questions. When the girl behind him, a ringleader of his tormentors, falsely claims that he scored zero, the entire class erupts in laughter at his expense. Ben's heartbreak and humiliation reach a breaking point, but he refuses to show weakness, masking his pain with a forced smile. Despite the overwhelming sense of loneliness and despair, Ben finds resilience within himself, determined not to succumb to the cruelty of his peers.

Through these experiences, Ben begins to confront his own identity and the systemic barriers he faces as a Black student in a predominantly White school system. Despite the adversity, he finds strength in his mother's unwavering support and her insistence that he can achieve anything he sets his mind to. These formative experiences sow the seeds of Ben's determination to rise above his circumstances and pursue his dream of becoming a doctor, setting the stage for his remarkable journey of resilience and achievement in the face of adversity.

Chapter 4

In Ben Carson's memoir, he recounts three incidents of racial prejudice and discrimination that he experienced during his adolescence, shedding light on the challenges faced by Black individuals in a predominantly White society.

The first incident occurred when Carson and his brother, Curtis, would hop trains to get to school. One day, Carson encountered a group of older White boys who verbally and physically assaulted him, using racial slurs and threats of violence. This traumatic experience led Carson to abandon train hopping altogether, fearing for his safety.

The second incident occurred during Carson's eighth-grade year when he was awarded the highest academic achievement certificate. Instead of celebrating his accomplishment, a teacher publicly berated the White students for allowing a Black student to outperform them academically. This blatant display of racism left Carson feeling hurt and angry, but he remained silent, choosing not to confront the teacher or report the incident to his mother.

The third incident involved Carson and his brother participating in a neighbourhood football league. Despite their talent and skill, they faced opposition from a group of White men who threatened them and ultimately forced them to quit the league. This incident highlighted the pervasive racism present in both organised sports and everyday life for Black individuals in their community.

Throughout these experiences, Carson grappled with feelings of fear, anger, and frustration, but he also demonstrated resilience and determination to overcome adversity. Despite the injustices he faced, Carson refused to let racism define him or deter him from pursuing his goals.

These incidents not only shaped Carson's worldview but also underscored the importance of confronting racism and advocating for equality and justice. By sharing his experiences, Carson sheds light on the systemic barriers faced by Black individuals and the need for continued efforts to combat racism and promote inclusivity in society.

Chapter 5

In this section of Ben Carson's memoir, he reflects on his experiences as a teenager, grappling with peer pressure, materialism, and a loss of focus on his academic goals. Carson recounts how, during his ninth-grade year, he could intellectually compete with the best students, but as he entered the tenth grade, the allure of fitting in with the popular crowd led him astray.

Carson describes how his obsession with clothing and appearances became a source of conflict with his mother, who emphasized the importance of character over material possessions. Despite her reluctance, Carson incessantly pressured his mother to buy him expensive, fashionable clothes to align with the expectations of his peers. This focus on external validation led Carson to neglect his academic responsibilities and prioritize social acceptance over his academic achievements.

As Carson's grades began to decline, he found himself drifting away from his academic ambitions and becoming more involved with the social scene. He recounts how he spent less time studying and more time participating in social activities with his peers, seeking validation and acceptance from the popular crowd.

Throughout this period, Carson reflects on the influence of his mother's faith and the teachings of the Seventh-day Adventist Church. He recalls how his mother's encounter with Mary Thomas, a devout Christian, provided her with a source of strength and stability during a difficult time in her life. Carson's upbringing in the Seventh-day Adventist faith instilled in him a strong moral foundation, despite his temporary lapse in focus during his teenage years.

As Carson approached adolescence, he grappled with questions of identity, faith, and personal responsibility. Despite his struggles, he remained grounded in his upbringing and eventually found his way back to his academic pursuits and spiritual convictions. This period of introspection and self-discovery laid the foundation for Carson's future success and resilience in the face of adversity.

Chapter 6

the story delves into a tumultuous period in the narrator's life where his temper proves to be a destructive force. It begins with a heated exchange between the narrator, Carson, and his classmate, Jerry, escalating to physical violence when Carson strikes Jerry with a lock during an argument. Regretful and apologetic, Carson realizes the severity of his temper after the incident.

The narrative then shifts to a confrontation with his mother over a pair of pants, which results in Carson almost striking her before being restrained by his brother. This incident serves as a stark realization of the danger his uncontrolled temper poses to those around him.

Carson reflects on past episodes where his anger led to violent outbursts, including throwing a rock at a neighbor and attempting to stab a friend. Horrified by his actions, Carson recognizes that his temper is not just a personality trait but a pathological issue that threatens his future aspirations, including his dream of becoming a doctor.

Feeling helpless and desperate for change, Carson turns to prayer in a moment of solitude in the bathroom. Despite skepticism about the possibility of altering his personality, he fervently pleads with God for help, acknowledging his inability to overcome his temper on his own.

As Carson prays and reads passages from Proverbs, he experiences a transformative spiritual awakening. He feels a profound sense of peace and resolve, convinced that God has answered his prayers and freed him from the grip of his temper. From that day forward, Carson commits himself to daily Bible reading and embraces his newfound faith as a source of strength and guidance.

Reflecting on his journey, Carson acknowledges the miraculous nature of his transformation and the enduring power of his faith in shaping his character. He learns to relinquish control to a higher power, finding solace and resilience in his relationship with Jesus Christ.

With his temper under control and his faith as a guiding light, Carson looks towards the future with optimism and determination. He credits his mother's teachings and his spiritual awakening for helping him overcome his inner demons and pursue his goals with renewed vigor.

In conclusion, Chapter 6 chronicles Carson's tumultuous struggle with his temper and his eventual triumph through faith and prayer. It serves as a testament to the transformative power of spirituality in overcoming personal challenges and forging a path towards redemption and self-discovery.

Chapter 7

The journey of Benjamin Carson towards his dream of becoming a doctor unfolds with remarkable determination and unexpected turns in Chapter 7, "ROTC Triumph."

At the tender age of 10, Carson was captivated by the accomplishments of Johns Hopkins University Hospital, sparking his ambition to become a doctor. As he grew older, his focus shifted towards psychiatry, inspired by the intellectual allure of TV psychiatrists and the prospect of financial stability in treating mental health issues.

Carson's brother Curtis played a pivotal role in nurturing his interests, gifting him a subscription to *Psychology Today* at 13. Despite initial struggles with the complex content, Carson delved into the world of psychology, honing his listening skills and offering counsel to peers.

Joining the ROTC in tenth grade marked a significant turning point for Carson. Influenced by Curtis's exemplary leadership, he set his sights on achieving high ranks within the program. Despite joining late and facing challenges, Carson's determination drove him to excel, earning promotions and accolades.

Throughout his high school years, Carson encountered influential figures who shaped his academic and personal growth. Teachers like Mrs. Miller and Mr. McCotter provided guidance and encouragement, instilling in him a sense of responsibility and academic excellence.

Carson's passion for knowledge extended beyond academics. He immersed himself in classical music, initially inspired by his brother's appreciation for it. Despite initial reluctance, Carson cultivated a deep appreciation for classical music, broadening his cultural horizons.

As Carson's achievements garnered attention, he was offered a full scholarship to West Point. However, his unwavering commitment to his dream of becoming a doctor led him to decline the offer, prioritizing his medical aspirations over a military career.

Despite his academic success and offers from prestigious universities, Carson remained grounded, recognizing the influence of his family and mentors in shaping his journey. He continued to pursue his passions, preparing diligently for opportunities like the College Bowl, showcasing his versatility and thirst for knowledge.

Chapter 7 encapsulates Carson's resilience, adaptability, and unwavering focus on his goals amidst challenges and temptations. It underscores the profound impact of familial support, mentorship, and personal determination in shaping his path towards a future in medicine.

Chapter 8

In Chapter 8, titled "College Choices," Benjamin Carson faces a pivotal decision about which college to apply to with only ten dollars in hand. Despite offers and inducements from prestigious colleges, he

could only afford to apply to one due to the application fees. While the University of Michigan waived fees for in-state students, Carson desired to attend college farther away. With excellent academic credentials and the desire to pursue a career in medicine, Carson ultimately chooses Yale after watching a televised College Bowl match where Yale outperforms Harvard.

Upon entering Yale, Carson's initial confidence takes a hit as he realizes the high level of competition among his peers. Despite his past academic achievements, he struggles to keep up with the rigorous coursework, especially in chemistry. As the semester progresses, he finds himself on the verge of failing chemistry, jeopardizing his dream of becoming a doctor.

Carson grapples with feelings of inadequacy, haunted by memories of childhood taunts and doubts about his abilities. Desperate and filled with self-doubt, he turns to prayer for guidance and assistance. Despite his efforts to cram for the final exam, Carson feels ill-prepared and resigned to failure.

In a moment of desperation, Carson experiences a vivid dream where he receives guidance on solving chemistry problems. Upon waking, he recalls the problems from the dream and finds them mirrored in the exam booklet. With newfound confidence and determination, Carson tackles the exam, realizing that the answers to the problems are the ones he saw in his dream. He finishes the exam with a sense of certainty that he will pass.

This miraculous experience reaffirms Carson's belief in God's guidance and his calling to become a physician. He resolves to improve his study habits and commits to fully understanding the material rather than relying on last-minute cramming. With a renewed sense of purpose, Carson embarks on his journey at Yale with the conviction that he is on the right path, determined to fulfill his potential and make a difference in the world.

Despite initial setbacks and doubts, Carson's resilience, faith, and unwavering determination ultimately lead him to academic success and confirm his calling to become a physician. This chapter highlights Carson's journey of self-discovery, spiritual awakening, and the transformative power of faith in overcoming challenges and achieving one's goals.

Chapter 9

In Chapter 9 of his autobiography, Ben Carson recounts his experiences during his college years and summer jobs. He emphasizes the importance of hard work, creativity, and determination in overcoming obstacles and achieving success.

During high school, Carson worked various summer jobs to save money for college expenses. With the help of a counselor, he secured a job at Ford Motor Company's payroll office, where he learned the importance of productivity and quality in the workplace.

While attending Yale University, Carson worked as a supervisor for a highway cleanup crew. Despite facing discipline issues with the crew initially, Carson motivated them to work efficiently, surpassing expectations and completing tasks quickly.

Carson shares his belief in challenging conventional rules and regulations when necessary to achieve better results. He recounts instances where he negotiated with his crew to work earlier hours for greater efficiency, despite conflicting with established work schedules.

After struggling to find summer employment one year, Carson took a bold step by reaching out to an influential contact from his past. Through persistence and networking, he secured a job at a prestigious advertising company, demonstrating the value of personal connections.

Carson's resourcefulness and determination are further highlighted when he faced financial difficulties during college. Despite hardships, he remained optimistic and relied on his faith, which was rewarded when he unexpectedly found money on two separate occasions.

In another instance, Carson displayed integrity during a challenging psychology exam, refusing to give in to the temptation to leave like many of his peers. His honesty was recognized by his professor, who commended him for his integrity and rewarded him with a monetary gift.

Throughout his narrative, Carson emphasizes the importance of hard work, integrity, and resilience in overcoming obstacles and achieving success. His experiences serve as valuable lessons on the power of determination and resourcefulness in navigating life's challenges.

Chapter 10

In Chapter 10 of Ben Carson's autobiography, titled "A Serious Step," Carson recounts his time at Yale and his blossoming relationship with Candy Rustin, which ultimately leads him to medical school. Here's a summary of the chapter:

Ben meets Candy Rustin, who introduces herself as Lacena Rustin, at a freshmen reception at the Grosse Pointe Country Club. Despite initially being focused on his studies and not ready for love, Ben is drawn to Candy's outgoing personality and intelligence. They become friends and often chat about their classes and interests.

Ben suggests Candy audition for the position of organist at his church, but she finds the music challenging and ends up joining the choir instead. Their friendship deepens as they attend Bible classes together, and Candy eventually becomes an active member of the Adventist church.

As their friendship grows, Ben and Candy spend more time together, including a memorable trip to Detroit for college recruiting. On the drive back to Yale, Ben falls asleep at the wheel, and they narrowly avoid a potentially fatal accident. This experience strengthens their bond, and they confess their feelings for each other, sharing their first kiss.

Despite their budding romance, both Ben and Candy remain committed to their studies. Ben applies to medical schools, confident that he will be accepted to the University of Michigan, while Candy continues her education at Yale. They maintain a long-distance relationship through letters and occasional phone calls.

During a summer break, Ben works at Sennet Steel, where he discovers his exceptional eye-hand coordination, which he believes is a divine gift. He also reflects on his study habits in medical school, realizing the importance of thorough textbook study over attending lectures.

As Ben excels in his medical studies and gains teaching experience, he prepares for his future career as a surgeon. Despite facing challenges and doubts from classmates, Ben remains confident in his abilities and trusts in God's plan for his life.

Overall, Chapter 10 highlights Ben's personal and academic growth, his blossoming relationship with Candy, and his unwavering faith in God's guidance.

Chapter 11

Chapter 11 Summary: Another Step Forward

In this chapter, Dr. Ben Carson reflects on his journey through neurosurgery, highlighting pivotal moments that shaped his career and personal life.

The chapter begins with Dr. Carson observing a skilled neurosurgeon struggling to locate the foramen ovale during surgery, sparking his determination to find a simpler method. After experimenting with different techniques, he develops a novel approach using X-rays and metal rings to pinpoint the location accurately. Despite initial doubts, his innovative method proves successful, earning praise from his professors.

Dr. Carson's passion for neurosurgery grows during his clinical year at the University of Michigan, where he excels beyond his peers. He eagerly takes on extra responsibilities, earning the trust of residents and professors alike. His dedication and expertise lead him to realize that neurosurgery is his true calling.

Amidst his flourishing career, Dr. Carson faces a pivotal decision about his residency. Concerned about the impending changes in the neurosurgery department at Michigan, he decides to apply to Johns Hopkins—a decision that ultimately leads to his acceptance into their prestigious neurosurgery program.

During his interview with Dr. George Udvarhelyi at Johns Hopkins, Dr. Carson's genuine passion for the field shines through. Despite an unexpected tangent into classical music, which Dr. Udvarhelyi finds impressive, Dr. Carson's credentials and demeanor secure his acceptance into the program.

Meanwhile, Dr. Carson's personal life flourishes as well. He marries Candy, his college sweetheart, and they move to Baltimore together. Candy juggles various jobs while pursuing her education, demonstrating resilience and determination.

In his residency at Johns Hopkins, Dr. Carson prioritizes building relationships with all hospital staff, recognizing their invaluable contributions to patient care. He learns from their expertise and fosters a collaborative environment, emphasizing the importance of treating everyone with respect and kindness.

Reflecting on his journey, Dr. Carson acknowledges the role of faith, hard work, and gratitude in his success. He credits his mother for instilling values of humility and compassion, which guide his interactions with others. He emphasizes the importance of recognizing and valuing the talents of every individual, regardless of their position.

Overall, Chapter 11 showcases Dr. Carson's unwavering dedication to neurosurgery, his commitment to excellence, and his belief in the power of collaboration and humility in achieving success. Through his experiences, he imparts valuable lessons on the importance of integrity, kindness, and perseverance in both personal and professional endeavors.

Chapter 12

Chapter 12: Coming Into My Own

In this chapter, Ben Carson reflects on his experiences as a young doctor, navigating through challenges and discrimination while striving to excel in his field.

He recalls instances where he was mistaken for an orderly because of his race, and encounters patients who expressed reluctance to have a Black doctor. However, his mentor, Dr. Long, stood firm against prejudice, reminding patients that Dr. Carson was qualified to treat them regardless of his race.

Despite facing prejudice, Dr. Carson remained focused on his goal of becoming a role model for Black youth. He believes that success comes from within and emphasizes the importance of self-reliance and hard work.

During his internship, Dr. Carson faced conflict with a chief resident named Tommy, who displayed racist behavior towards him. However, Dr. Carson remained composed and focused on his duties, refusing to let the negativity affect him.

Dr. Carson's interest in neurosurgery grew during his residency at Johns Hopkins. He pursued research on brain tumors, developing a model using New Zealand white rabbits. With collaborative effort, he successfully created a consistent and reliable model for studying brain tumors, earning recognition and awards for his work.

As a chief resident, Dr. Carson honed his surgical skills, performing complex procedures with precision and confidence. Despite the challenges he faced, he emerged from his residency ready to embark on the next chapter of his career.

Overall, this chapter highlights Dr. Carson's resilience in the face of adversity and his dedication to making a difference in the medical field. His journey serves as an inspiration for overcoming obstacles and achieving success through hard work and perseverance.

Chapter 13

Summary:

Dr. Ben Carson reflects on a pivotal year in his career, during which he was invited to work in Australia, despite initial reservations due to concerns about racial discrimination. However, after learning that Australia had abolished its Whites-only policy, Dr. Carson and his wife, Candy, decided to take the opportunity. In Australia, Dr. Carson gained valuable surgical experience, particularly in neurosurgery, and was warmly welcomed by the community. He performed several successful surgeries, including a challenging case where he saved a patient's cranial nerves. Additionally, Candy gave birth to their first son during their time in Australia.

Upon returning to the United States, Dr. Carson faced offers to work at a hospital specializing in medical services for Black communities, but he ultimately chose to stay at Johns Hopkins Hospital. Despite concerns about potential racism, Dr. Carson found himself thriving at Hopkins, receiving numerous referrals and eventually being appointed as the chief of pediatric neurosurgery. His appointment was met with surprise from some patients, both Black and White, but Dr. Carson's skill and expertise quickly won them over.

Dr. Carson's career continued to flourish at Hopkins, and he faced challenges such as a particularly difficult surgery on a young girl named Maranda. The outcome of Maranda's case had a significant impact on the medical profession's perception of a controversial surgical procedure.

Throughout his journey, Dr. Carson remained humble and grateful for the opportunities he had been given. He recognized the importance of continued learning and collaboration with other doctors, and he was dedicated to providing the best possible care for his patients.

In summary, Dr. Carson's experience in Australia provided him with invaluable surgical experience and paved the way for his successful career as a pediatric neurosurgeon at Johns Hopkins Hospital. Despite facing initial doubts and concerns, Dr. Carson persevered and ultimately achieved remarkable success in his field.

Chapter 14

Chapter 14 of "Gifted Hands" recounts the harrowing journey of Maranda Francisco, a young girl suffering from debilitating seizures caused by a rare condition called Rasmussen's encephalitis. Maranda's parents, Terry and Luis Francisco, endured years of despair as they watched their daughter's health deteriorate while seeking help from numerous doctors and hospitals, only to be met with disappointment and hopelessness.

Maranda's seizures began at just 18 months old, growing progressively worse over time and eventually leaving her unable to eat, walk, talk, or learn. Despite their modest income, the Franciscos refused to give up on their daughter, tirelessly seeking answers and exploring every possible avenue for treatment.

After finally receiving a diagnosis of Rasmussen's encephalitis, which typically leads to paralysis, mental retardation, and death, Maranda's parents were devastated to learn that the condition was deemed inoperable. However, their determination led them to contact Dr. John Freeman at Johns Hopkins Hospital, renowned for his expertise in treating seizures.

Dr. Freeman saw promise in Maranda's case and suggested a radical procedure known as a hemispherectomy, in which one hemisphere of the brain is removed. Despite never having performed the surgery himself, Dr. Freeman believed it offered a chance to save Maranda's life.

Dr. Ben Carson, a pediatric neurosurgeon at Johns Hopkins, carefully evaluated Maranda's case and ultimately agreed to attempt the hemispherectomy, despite the inherent risks involved. He candidly explained the potential complications to the Franciscos, emphasizing the possibility of death or severe brain damage.

In the face of uncertainty, Maranda's parents bravely consented to the surgery, knowing it was their daughter's only hope for a better life. Dr. Carson prepared them for the possibility of the worst outcome but also encouraged them to hold onto hope.

The night before the surgery, Dr. Carson met with the Franciscos to ensure they fully understood the risks involved. Despite the gravity of the situation, Terry and Luis remained resolute in their decision, believing it was their daughter's best chance for survival.

As Dr. Carson prepared for the surgery, he reflected on the potential outcomes and found solace in his faith, trusting that he was doing everything he could to help Maranda. With a sense of peace, he approached the operation, knowing that they were giving the young girl a fighting chance at life.

Chapter 14 of "Gifted Hands" serves as a poignant reminder of the power of perseverance, hope, and faith in the face of adversity. Through the unwavering determination of Maranda's parents and the skill and compassion of her medical team, a ray of hope emerges in the midst of despair, offering the promise of a brighter future for a courageous young girl.

Chapter 15

Chapter 15 of Ben Carson's autobiography, "Gifted Hands," delves into a groundbreaking surgical procedure and the emotional toll it takes on both the surgeon and the patient's family. Dr. Carson undertakes a hemispherectomy on Maranda Francisco, a procedure with few recorded cases of full functional recovery. Despite the risks, Dr. Carson is determined to do his best, relying on his preparation and faith.

The surgery proves to be challenging from the start, lasting twice as long as expected due to Maranda's inflamed brain and profuse bleeding. Dr. Carson meticulously removes the inflamed left hemisphere of Maranda's brain over eight tedious hours, facing the daunting task of preserving vital blood vessels and delicate brain tissue.

Maranda loses a significant amount of blood during the surgery, but Dr. Carson and his team manage to replace it. The surgery concludes successfully, and Maranda's parents anxiously await her recovery. Miraculously, Maranda wakes up and speaks to her parents shortly after the surgery, defying expectations by showing signs of alertness and responsiveness despite the removal of the brain's dominant speech area.

The media coverage following Maranda's surgery surprises Dr. Carson, who sees it as inevitable rather than newsworthy. Despite invitations to appear on television shows, Dr. Carson declines, wary of becoming a celebrity doctor and prioritizing his medical responsibilities.

The success of Maranda's surgery highlights the concept of plasticity, where the brain adapts and compensates for lost functions, particularly in children. Dr. Carson explains that plasticity is more pronounced in younger patients, leading to remarkable recovery outcomes.

Dr. Carson reflects on the emotional toll of losing a patient, particularly Jennifer, a young child who underwent a hemispherectomy. Despite the successful surgery, Jennifer tragically passes away shortly after, leaving Dr. Carson devastated. He grapples with feelings of guilt and responsibility, but

ultimately finds solace in knowing that he and his team did everything possible for Jennifer and other patients.

Despite the challenges and emotional pain, Dr. Carson remains committed to his patients and his work, acknowledging the importance of empathy and human connection in his practice. He recognizes the privilege and responsibility of holding patients' lives in his hands and continues to strive for excellence in his surgical career.

Chapter 16

In Chapter 16 of "Gifted Hands" by Dr. Ben Carson, we follow the stories of two young patients, Beth Usher and Denise Baca, who underwent hemispherectomies, a radical surgical procedure to treat severe epilepsy.

Beth Usher's journey began in 1985 when she experienced her first seizure after falling from a swing. Despite initial reassurances from medical professionals, Beth's seizures continued to worsen in frequency, prompting her parents, Brian and Kathy Usher, to seek every possible solution. After learning about hemispherectomies at Johns Hopkins, they met with Dr. Carson, who explained the risks and potential benefits of the surgery. Initially hesitant due to Beth's relatively stable condition, the Ushers ultimately decided to proceed with the surgery as her seizures worsened.

The surgery itself went smoothly, but Beth experienced complications afterward, including swelling in her brain stem. Despite efforts to reassure the Ushers, they struggled with guilt and uncertainty as they watched their daughter's condition deteriorate. Eventually, Beth showed signs of improvement, such as speaking for the first time since the surgery, giving hope to her family.

Denise Baca's case presented a different set of challenges. Suffering from constant seizures and severe medical complications, Denise's condition seemed dire. Despite opposition from some medical professionals, Dr. Carson and his team believed that a hemispherectomy offered Denise the best chance for improvement. After careful consideration and discussion, they proceeded with the surgery while the main critic was away, leading to Denise's successful recovery.

Reflecting on these experiences, Dr. Carson emphasizes the importance of perseverance, faith, and expertise in overcoming challenges. Despite facing criticism and doubt, he remained steadfast in his commitment to providing the best possible care for his patients. Ultimately, both Beth and Denise's stories serve as testaments to the power of medical innovation and the resilience of the human spirit.

Chapter 17

Chapter 17 of the book recounts the remarkable stories of three special children who faced life-threatening medical situations and the extraordinary efforts made to save them.

The chapter begins with the story of Bo-Bo Valentine, a 4-year-old girl who suffered severe head trauma after being hit by a Good Humor truck. Despite efforts to control the pressure in her brain, Bo-Bo's condition continued to deteriorate until her pupils suddenly dilated, signaling a critical emergency. Despite opposition from a senior neurosurgeon, Dr. Carson proceeded with emergency

surgery, performing a craniectomy to relieve pressure on Bo-Bo's brain. Miraculously, Bo-Bo gradually regained consciousness and eventually made a full recovery, defying the odds.

The narrative then shifts to Charles, a 10-year-old boy who faced a similar situation after being struck by a car. Despite initial reluctance from Charles's mother, who was understandably hesitant to consent to risky surgery, Dr. Carson persuaded her by emphasizing the slim but vital chance of saving Charles's life. Once again, Dr. Carson performed a craniectomy, and despite skepticism from some medical professionals, Charles eventually regained consciousness and began to recover, albeit more slowly than Bo-Bo.

The chapter concludes with the poignant story of Danielle, a five-month-old infant born with a massive tumor protruding from her head. Danielle's mother, determined to fight for her daughter's life despite discouragement from others, reached out to Dr. Carson after reading about his willingness to tackle difficult cases. Dr. Carson collaborated with other medical experts to devise a complex surgical plan to remove the tumor and reconstruct Danielle's skull. The surgery, lasting 19 hours, was successful, but Danielle's health began to decline due to complications from the tumor's metastasis. Despite the heartbreaking outcome, Danielle's family expressed gratitude for the efforts made to save her life.

These stories exemplify Dr. Carson's unwavering commitment to providing hope and compassionate care to his patients, even in the face of daunting challenges and uncertain outcomes. Through his dedication and expertise, he demonstrates the profound impact that medical intervention can have on the lives of those facing life-threatening illnesses and injuries.

Chapter 18

Chapter 18 of the book recounts the remarkable journey of Craig and Susan Warnick as they navigate through Craig's battle with Von Hippel-Lindau (VHL) disease, a rare genetic condition that causes multiple tumors in various parts of the body, including the brain.

The chapter begins with a scene of hope and prayer in Craig's hospital room, where friends and family gather to pray for him as he undergoes surgery. Despite the uncertainty, there is a sense of faith and optimism among them.

Susan, Craig's devoted wife and a nurse herself, reflects on their journey together, from their high school days to facing the challenges of Craig's illness. Despite the hardships, their faith in God remains unwavering.

Craig's battle with VHL disease began in high school when he was diagnosed with a brain tumor. Over the years, he undergoes multiple surgeries and treatments, each presenting its own set of challenges and setbacks. However, through Susan's unwavering support and their shared faith, Craig perseveres.

Their faith is put to the test when Craig faces yet another brain tumor in an inoperable location. Despite the grim prognosis, they continue to believe in the possibility of a miracle.

Dr. Ben Carson, a renowned neurosurgeon, becomes involved in Craig's case and performs a risky surgery to remove the tumor. Despite the odds, Craig miraculously survives the surgery and begins to recover, defying all expectations.

The chapter concludes with Susan reflecting on the emotional rollercoaster of their journey, from despair to hope and finally, to gratitude for the miraculous outcome. Through it all, their faith in God sustains them, and they find joy in the simple moments of life, such as Craig's ability to eat a plate of spaghetti and meatballs without difficulty—a reminder of the miracles that can happen in the midst of adversity.

Overall, Chapter 18 is a testament to the power of faith, love, and perseverance in the face of adversity, and the miraculous outcomes that can occur when one holds onto hope.

Chapter 19

Theresa Binder's world was shattered when she learned that she was pregnant with Siamese twins. Faced with overwhelming despair and thoughts of ending her own life and that of her unborn twins, Theresa struggled to come to terms with the news. However, she eventually made peace with herself and resolved to face whatever challenges lay ahead.

Before their birth, Theresa and her husband Josef had been filled with joy at the prospect of twins. But when Patrick and Benjamin were born joined at the back of their heads, their joy turned to concern for their sons' future. Determined to give their sons a chance at a normal life, the Binders hoped for a miracle that would separate the twins.

Their hopes were answered when a team of doctors from Johns Hopkins agreed to perform the risky surgery to separate Patrick and Benjamin. The team, led by Dr. Ben Carson, spent months preparing for the complex procedure. Finally, in September 1987, the surgery began.

The operation was fraught with challenges from the start. The twins' shared anatomy presented unique difficulties, and unforeseen complications arose during the procedure. Despite the obstacles, the surgical team remained focused on their goal of separating the twins and giving them a chance to live independently.

After hours of intense surgery, Patrick and Benjamin were successfully separated. However, the challenges were far from over. The twins faced life-threatening bleeding and swelling in their brains, requiring additional intervention from the medical team.

Through perseverance and dedication, the doctors managed to stabilize the twins and begin the process of healing. Despite the setbacks, Theresa and Josef remained hopeful for their sons' future.

As the twins continued to recover, the medical team worked tirelessly to address the remaining challenges. Additional surgeries were planned to reconstruct the twins' skulls and ensure their long-term well-being.

Despite the uncertainty and hardships they faced, the Binders remained steadfast in their love and support for Patrick and Benjamin. Their journey was a testament to the power of hope, determination, and the unwavering bond between a parent and child.

In the end, Patrick and Benjamin's story was one of resilience and triumph. Against all odds, they defied the limitations of their condition and embraced the opportunity for a new beginning, thanks to the skill and dedication of their medical team and the unwavering love of their parents.

Chapter 20

Summary:

The story narrates the separation surgery of conjoined twins, Patrick and Benjamin Binder, performed by a team led by Dr. Ben Carson at Johns Hopkins Hospital. The surgery, lasting 22 hours, was successful, but the twins were placed in an artificial coma using phenobarbital to aid recovery and reduce brain swelling. The public was informed about the historic surgery, which garnered widespread media attention and public interest.

Following the surgery, the twins remained in a coma for ten days. The medical team monitored their vital signs and observed signs of progress, such as softening skin flaps indicating reduced swelling. Eventually, both twins woke from the coma, prompting celebrations throughout the hospital.

However, Patrick experienced a setback when he aspirated food into his lungs, leading to respiratory arrest and potential brain damage. Despite this, both twins made progress in their recovery, with Benjamin continuing to improve even after Patrick's setback.

Due to contractual agreements, no further updates on the twins' progress after leaving Johns Hopkins Hospital are provided in the narrative.

Throughout the ordeal, Dr. Carson expresses gratitude for the teamwork and dedication of the medical staff involved in the surgery and postoperative care. He acknowledges the uncertainties and challenges of the situation but remains hopeful and thankful for the progress made.

In conclusion, the story highlights the remarkable surgical feat of separating conjoined twins and the subsequent challenges and triumphs in their recovery journey.

Chapter 21

Summary:

The chapter recounts Dr. Ben Carson's experience with the birth of his second son, Benjamin Carson Jr., and the challenges he faced balancing his demanding neurosurgical career with his family life.

In the early hours of May 26, 1985, Dr. Carson's wife, Candy, went into labor unexpectedly at home. Dr. Carson assisted in the delivery, catching the baby boy, and quickly called for medical assistance. This event made him reflect on his hectic schedule and the need to prioritize his family.

Dr. Carson grappled with the dilemma of managing his career at Johns Hopkins Hospital while dedicating time to his family. He recognized the unpredictability of neurosurgery, with its demanding and complex cases requiring significant time commitments. Despite his passion for his work, Dr. Carson decided to make changes to ensure he spent more quality time with his family.

His priorities shifted, placing family first, followed by his clinical responsibilities and serving as a role model for young people. Dr. Carson made the difficult decision to leave work by 7:00 or 8:00 p.m. every evening to spend time with his children before they went to bed. This change required him to reevaluate his commitments and give up certain activities, such as extensive research and speaking engagements, that would have furthered his career.

Dr. Carson's decision to prioritize family was supported by his wife, Candy, who understood the demands of his profession. Despite their busy schedules, they maintained a strong partnership, with Candy pursuing her own interests and creative endeavors while managing the household.

The chapter concludes with Dr. Carson reflecting on the importance of being present in his children's lives and ensuring they know him as more than just a distant figure. He emphasizes the significance of his family and acknowledges the support and understanding of his wife in navigating the challenges of balancing career and family life.

Overall, the chapter highlights Dr. Carson's journey toward achieving a better work-life balance and the importance of prioritizing family amidst the demands of a demanding career in neurosurgery.

Chapter 22

In Chapter 22 of Ben Carson's autobiography, "Gifted Hands," he discusses his vision for a national scholarship fund to support academically talented yet financially disadvantaged young people. Carson and his wife, Candy, dream of creating a scholarship program that focuses on recognizing pure talent in any field, without political influence or the need for connections.

Carson emphasizes the importance of thinking big and shares an acrostic, THINK BIG, to convey his philosophy on success:

- **Talent and Time:** Recognize and develop your God-given talents, and understand the value of time management.
- **Hope and Honesty:** Maintain a positive outlook and practice honesty in all aspects of life.
- **Insight:** Learn from those who have gone before you and seek knowledge from sources like books and mentors.
- **Nice:** Treat others with kindness and respect, as it takes less energy to be nice than to be mean.
- **Knowledge:** Value education and strive to become knowledgeable in your field of interest.
- **Books and In-Depth Learning:** Read actively and seek to understand deeply rather than superficially.
- **God:** Remain humble and maintain a connection with your faith.

Carson reflects on his commitment to inspiring and mentoring young people, especially those from disadvantaged backgrounds. He believes that with the right support and encouragement, these individuals can achieve outstanding results. Carson is dedicated to teaching young people how to set goals, work hard, and overcome obstacles in pursuit of their dreams.

He critiques the media's emphasis on sports and entertainment over academic and intellectual pursuits, encouraging young people to focus on self-improvement and education rather than solely on fame and

fortune. Carson believes that by providing positive role models and promoting the value of education, communities can empower young people to reach their full potential.

Carson shares stories of individuals whose lives have been transformed by his example and encourages others to recognize their own God-given talents and use them to overcome challenges. He emphasizes that success requires perseverance and a willingness to view obstacles as opportunities for growth.

Overall, Carson's message in this chapter is one of empowerment, urging readers to think big, pursue their passions, and strive for excellence in every aspect of life. He emphasizes the importance of education, hard work, and integrity in achieving success and making a positive impact on the world.